

SIG on Designing for Constructive Conflict

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ABSTRACT

Online arguments are an increasingly important and controversial part of modern life. From the spread of political conspiracies to managing relationships while socially distanced, the past several years have stressed the role technology plays in our interactions with one another. And unavoidably, part of maintaining relationships includes managing conflict and disagreements, from who does which chores to who's a better political candidate. This SIG will bring together an interdisciplinary group of designers and researchers to discuss how to design, build, and evaluate systems to support constructive arguments online. We ask: How can online systems support conflict while sustaining and possibly strengthening interpersonal relationships? We will explore these questions in the context of a collaborative literature review across fields relevant to social computing and the psychology of conflict, paired with group discussion on how to design for disagreements.

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1 INTRODUCTION

Online arguments are increasingly prevalent and influential in society, as people spend more time online than ever before [5]. Engaging in arguments online can have positive consequences for the individuals involved and the society as a whole. Arguments, especially political ones, can help people learn about opposing viewpoints, obtain new information and gain alternate perspectives, contributing to a vibrant deliberative democracy. People are optimistic about the potential for social media and online communication to allow them to engage in productive disagreements [2]. They employ numerous strategies to identify and productively engage with opposing views even in extremely contentious circumstances [6]. Although people report that they rarely change their views [4, 11], being polite and

engaging in a debate can feel like a worthwhile and productive endeavor, even if only anonymously with strangers online [4]. This indicates that even though people increasingly worry about the potential for social media to create division [9], engaging in online arguments can still be beneficial.

Conflict is also an unavoidable and essential part of close interpersonal relationships [1], and many people choose to carry out these conversations through social media platforms [2, 7]. However, at their worst, online arguments can have serious negative influences on relationships, both online and offline. When people disagree, this may lead to the dissolution of online relationships through unfriending [8], and people can even lose jobs or end friendships due to online posts [10]. Even when two people are committed to working through a disagreement together, they often prefer to resolve arguments offline, where they can more easily adapt to nonverbal social cues [7]. Across various online platforms and interaction mechanisms, people are excited about the potential for design to empower them to argue more effectively, while simultaneously worried that naïve interventions would backfire or intrude during an already delicate interpersonal process.

Therefore, it is important that designers and researchers explore the nuances of these interactions so that we may design, create, and evaluate systems that support working through disagreements, in such a way that allows users to reap the benefits of honest disagreement, without damage to their relationships. In this SIG, we will explore the various contexts in which users engage in online arguments and how to design to support them. We will explore how to support both *individuals* and *relationships* as part of a conversation with a well-known other. Our goal is to connect researchers and designers from a variety of backgrounds to spur collaborations and further research that shifts focus from *users* to *relationships*. To further this goal, in this SIG we will:

- Bring together a diverse group of designers, social scientists and practitioners interested in designing to facilitate constructive conflict online while sustaining and strengthening interpersonal relationships.
- Collate research across these various disciplines and identify key ideas to pursue in future work.
- Spark collaboration and build interdisciplinary connections.

Our ultimate goal is that this SIG will foster future research collaborations, and we additionally plan to produce an article to be submitted to ACM *Interactions* magazine.

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2 THE SIG

As the field of HCI stems primarily from computer science, it is appealing to view online conflict through a technosolutionist mindset, meaning the highest priority is placed on engineered solutions to human problems. However, prior work has also found that unnecessary or intrusive online interventions during conflict can escalate the situation [2]. Additionally, conflict is inherently personal, and different conflict management styles can lead to equally satisfying long term relationships [3], which indicates that interventions require a nuanced understanding of the relationship dynamics they seek to support. Therefore, technologists need to be very cautious in their approach to supporting constructive conflict.

Our goal is that this SIG will surface new understanding on how (and when) to design solutions for something as personal as online conflict and provide an opportunity for scholars with similar interests from various disciplines to join together to discuss the challenges of this space. As online conflict can compose so many various types of content and relationships, we will exclude analysis of the role of bots, trolls, and anonymous users. We will solely focus on how to design to engage in conflict when two people already know each other.

2.1 Logistics

The format for the SIG overall will mix synchronous and asynchronous communication over a several week period, with a goal of allowing broad participation. For the two weeks leading up to the SIG, we will encourage participants to introduce themselves and connect with other participants via a Slack channel. We will also encourage participants to send along one paper from a field outside of HCI that they think is relevant to the study of interpersonal conflict and conflict resolution in a designated Slack channel. Finally, we will send a Google Form to participants to ask what topics they would like to discuss or see discussed at the SIG, to ensure that we are drawing from the expertise of the community.

This event will engage on the following topics as a starting point, though we will modify this list as attendees give input:

- How do we support users' self reflection before, during, and after online conflict?
- How do we consider the trade-offs between users agency and guiding user behavior during conflict?
- When is it advisable to disengage from conflict entirely?
- What types of goals might people have during online conflict?
- When is it advisable to engage in conflict in an offline setting rather than online?
- How do we design for conflict when those in conflict have different needs than our own? (This can be along dimensions of personality, ability, communication style, etc.)

2.2 Post-SIG Communications and Continuity

Any guidelines or findings from the SIG will be compiled and disseminated via publication in *Interactions*. For more broad reach, a full recap of the discussion will also be distributed via social platforms. Before and during the SIG, we will encourage networking and exploring collaborations, especially with those they have not yet had the opportunity to meet or work with. We plan to leave

the Slack workspace standing so that participants can continue to connect after the event. We anticipate it will continue to be a place for sharing relevant publications and sparking communication with scholars with similar interests.

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